

Multimodal Fake News Detection Using RoBERTa and Vision Transformer with Late Fusion Strategy

**Project report submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements
for the award of the degree
BACHELOR OF TECHNOLOGY
in
COMPUTER SCIENCE& ENGINEERING (DATA SCIENCE)**

Submitted by

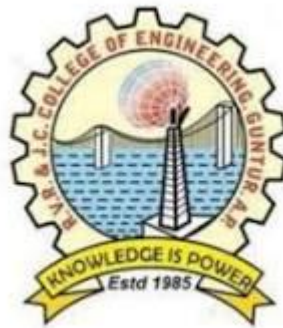
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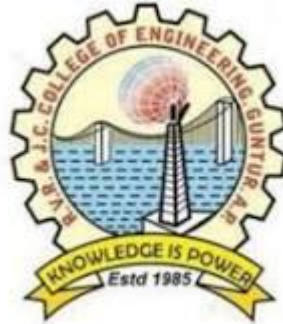
R.V.R & J.C. COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING (AUTONOMOUS)

Approved by AICTE- New Delhi, Accredited by NAAC A+ Grade

**Affiliated to Acharya Nagarjuna University,
Chowdavaram, Guntur - 19, Andhra Pradesh, India.**

MAY 2026

R.V.R & J.C. COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING (AUTONOMOUS)
DEPARTMENT OF
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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the project work titled “**Multimodal Fake News Detection Using RoBERTa and Vision Transformer with Late Fusion Strategy**” is the work done by **N. Dharma Teja (Y22CD116)** and **M.Kavya (Y22CD089)** under my supervision and submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of the degree, B.Tech. in Computer Science and Engineering (Data Science), during the Academic Year 2025-2026.

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DECLARATION

We **N. Dharma Teja(Y22CD116)** and **M. Kavya(Y22CD089)** hereby declare that the project report titled “**Multimodal Fake News Detection Using RoBERTa and Vision Transformer with Late Fusion Strategy**” under the guidance of **Dr. A.V. Ramakrishna** is submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of the degree of Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science and Engineering (Data Science). This is a record of bonafide work carried out by us and the results embodied in this project have not been reproduced or copied from any source. The results embodied in this project have not been submitted to any other university for the award of any other degree.

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Date:

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

The successful completion of any task would be incomplete without proper suggestion, guidance, and environment. Combination of these three factors acts like a backbone to our project work “**Multimodal Fake News Detection Using RoBERTa and Vision Transformer with Late Fusion Strategy**”.

We are profoundly pleased to express our deep sense of gratitude and respect towards the management of the **R.V.R. & J.C. College of Engineering** for providing the resources to complete the project.

We are very much thankful to **Dr. Kolla Srinivas**, Principal, **R.V.R. & J.C. College of Engineering** for allowing us to deliver the project successfully.

We are greatly indebted to **Dr. M.V.P. Chandra Sekhara Rao**, Professor, & Head of the department, Computer Science and Engineering (Data Science), **R.V.R. & J.C. College of Engineering**, providing the laboratory facilities fully as and when required and for giving us the opportunity to carry the project work in the college.

We are also thankful to our Project Coordinator **Dr. Popuri Srinivas Rao**, Associate Professor who helped us in each step of our Project.

We are very much thankful to our Project guide **Dr. A.V. Ramakrishna**, Associate Professor who has inspired us to take this project and gave us valuable guidance to complete the project successfully.

We would be thankful to **all the staff** of the Department of Computer Science and Engineering (Data Science) for their valuable suggestions, guidance and constructive ideas in each and every step, which was indeed of great help towards the successful completion of our project.

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ABSTRACT

The proliferation of multimodal misinformation across social media platforms poses a critical challenge for automated fact-verification systems. Fabricated news increasingly exploits both persuasive language and synthetically manipulated visual media, rendering single-modality detection approaches insufficient. This project proposes a Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework integrating two specialised Transformer-based expert models: RoBERTa for deep linguistic analysis and Vision Transformer (ViT) for visual deepfake forensics. Rather than coupling modalities at the feature level, a Late Fusion strategy combines independently calibrated probability scores via a weighted decision rule ($P_{\text{final}} = 0.4 \times P_{\text{text}} + 0.6 \times P_{\text{vision}}$), reflecting the stronger forensic evidence present in visually manipulated content. The framework is trained and evaluated on three public benchmarks - FakeNewsNet, SocialDF, and FACTIFY 2 - and achieves an F1-score of 92.6% with an AUC of 0.967, outperforming text-only, vision-only, and early-fusion baselines by margins of +10.4, +13.1, and +7.5 percentage points respectively. The modular architecture supports independent model retraining, partial-modality inference, and real-time deployment at approximately 14 posts per second on a single GPU.

Keywords: Fake news detection, multimodal misinformation, RoBERTa, Vision Transformer, deepfake forensics, late fusion, social media analysis, transformer models.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction

The rapid proliferation of social media has fundamentally transformed information creation and consumption at global scale. While this democratisation of communication enables faster knowledge dissemination, it has simultaneously created fertile conditions for misinformation to spread with unprecedented speed and reach. Modern fake news has evolved beyond simple textual fabrications: it now systematically combines persuasive rhetoric with manipulated images, out-of-context photographs, and AI-generated deepfake videos, creating multimodal deceptions that are significantly more difficult to detect and debunk [1,3].

Traditional approaches to automated fake news detection have focused predominantly on textual analysis. Natural Language Processing (NLP) techniques examine linguistic patterns, sentiment distributions, stylistic markers, and semantic inconsistencies to distinguish authentic reporting from fabricated content. While effective against purely [11, 14]text-based misinformation, these systems fail critically when false narratives are supported by visually convincing synthetic media. Conversely, visual forensic systems designed to detect deepfakes and image manipulation cannot identify cases where authentic visuals are misappropriated to support misleading textual claims [2,4].

The convergence of adversarial AI content generation with coordinated disinformation campaigns has made this challenge particularly acute. Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs), diffusion models, and face-swapping architectures can now produce photorealistic synthetic faces and video with minimal computational resources, dramatically lowering the barrier to creating convincing deepfake misinformation at scale. Simultaneously, large language models capable of generating stylistically consistent, factually plausible disinformation text have further complicated the detection landscape [6,7,9].

1.2 Problem Statement

Addressing this multimodal challenge requires detection systems capable of simultaneously reasoning across both textual and visual evidence. A robust solution must evaluate not only whether the textual claim exhibits suspicious linguistic patterns, but also whether the associated visual content has been synthetically generated, digitally altered, or semantically misappropriated from unrelated contexts. Critically, the system must assess cross-modal consistency: whether the visual evidence genuinely supports the textual claim.

Single-modality systems suffer from fundamental blind spots - NLP models miss visual manipulation while computer vision forensic tools cannot assess textual credibility. Early and intermediate fusion approaches that couple modalities at the feature level introduce inter-modality interference during training, preventing each branch from developing maximally specialised representations. A deployment-grade system must also handle scenarios where one modality is absent, compressed, or corrupted, which is a common occurrence in real-world social media content [2,4].

1.3 Objectives of the Study

This project proposes a Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework that integrates two specialised Transformer-based expert models: RoBERTa for linguistic misinformation analysis and Vision Transformer (ViT) for visual deepfake forensics, combined through an empirically calibrated Late Fusion strategy. The principal objectives are:

- (1) To design a two-branch multimodal architecture pairing fine-tuned RoBERTa with ViT for independent, specialised modality analysis without inter-modality interference during training.
- (2) To develop a weighted Late Fusion decision rule with fusion coefficient empirically calibrated via grid search on held-out validation data, achieving superior performance over feature-level fusion baselines.

(3) To comprehensively benchmark the system across three complementary public datasets representing textual misinformation, deepfake video, and cross-modal entailment scenarios.

(4) To deliver a modular, deployment-ready architecture supporting independent model upgrades, graceful degradation under missing modalities, and real-time social media monitoring inference throughput.

The proposed framework addresses these objectives by leveraging the complementary strengths of transformer-based language models and vision transformers in a modular, independently trainable pipeline. The Late Fusion architecture ensures that each expert model develops maximally specialised representations for its respective modality before evidence is combined at the decision level. This approach is grounded in ensemble diversity theory, which predicts that combining independently trained classifiers with uncorrelated error patterns reduces aggregate variance proportionally to their error correlation [21,28].

The framework is designed with practical deployment constraints in mind. Social media platforms operate at immense scale, processing millions of posts per hour. A detection system must therefore achieve both high accuracy and low inference latency to be practically viable. The proposed system achieves approximately 14 posts per second on a single GPU, demonstrating that Transformer-based multimodal misinformation detection is not merely theoretically sound but operationally feasible for real-world content moderation pipelines [25,29].

Chapter 2

Literature Survey

2. TERATURE SURVEY

2.1 Literature Survey

Multimodal misinformation detection has emerged from two largely parallel lines of research: NLP-based fake news detection and computer vision-based deepfake forensics, with more recent work attempting to bridge the two modalities.

Transformer architectures, introduced by Vaswani et al. (2017), revolutionised NLP by replacing sequential recurrent processing with parallelisable self-attention mechanisms. BERT demonstrated that deeply bidirectional Transformer pretraining on large unlabelled corpora followed by task-specific fine-tuning substantially outperforms task-specific architectures trained from scratch. RoBERTa improved upon BERT through dynamic masking, training on substantially larger corpora (160 GB versus 16 GB), and removal of next-sentence prediction, making it particularly sensitive to stylistic markers of misinformation such as exaggerated claims, emotional amplification, and absence of verifiable attributions [11, 14].

Convolutional Neural Networks have long dominated image analysis, but their reliance on local receptive fields limits detection of global structural inconsistencies. Vision Transformers (ViT) address this by treating images as sequences of fixed-size patches with global self-attention across all patch positions simultaneously. For deepfake detection, this global reasoning capability is particularly valuable in identifying boundary discontinuities, irregular illumination gradients, GAN spectral bias artefacts, and texture transition discontinuities at facial region boundaries.

Early multimodal approaches concatenated independently extracted text and image features before classification, achieving modest improvements over unimodal baselines [18,19]. Subsequent work explored cross-modal attention mechanisms that explicitly align textual entities with image regions [10,19]. Graph-based approaches modelled social engagement context alongside content features. More recent contrastive pretraining on text-image pairs has shown promise, but tight modality coupling makes systems brittle when one modality is absent [10,20].

Deepfake detection has been approached through frequency domain analysis, biological signal exploitation, and geometric consistency verification . Transformer-based approaches have demonstrated superior generalisation compared to CNN-based methods on out-of-distribution generation techniques, motivating the choice of ViT as the visual forensic backbone in this work [12, 17].

Table 2.1: Literature Survey on Related Works in Multimodal Misinformation Detection

Authors (Year)	Method / Model	Dataset	Key Contribution
Shu et al. (2017)	NLP + propagation analysis	FakeNewsNet	Social context improves detection
Nakamura et al. (2020)	Multimodal CNN + BERT	Fakeddit	Multimodal outperforms unimodal
Tan et al. (2022)	Cross-modal attention	FACTIFY	Semantic misalignment detection
Wei et al. (2022)	Hierarchical Graph CNN	Weibo	Graph propagation + content fusion
Dolhansky et al. (2020)	CNN deepfake detection	DFDC	Real-world deepfake evaluation
Zhao et al. (2021)	Multi-attentional ViT	FaceForensics+ +	ViT outperforms CNN on deepfakes
Liu et al. (2019)	RoBERTa fine-tuning	NLP benchmarks	Robust BERT pretraining for NLP
Dosovitskiy et al. (2021)	Vision Transformer (ViT)	ImageNet	Global self-attention for vision

Chapter 3

System Analysis & Feasibility Study

3. SYSTEM ANALYSIS & FEASIBILITY STUDY

3.1 Existing System

Existing automated misinformation detection systems are predominantly unimodal. NLP-based systems such as fine-tuned BERT and RoBERTa models analyse textual linguistic patterns - sentiment, hedging language, source attribution - and achieve state-of-the-art accuracy in the range of 80-85% on FakeNewsNet. These systems fail completely [11,25] when false narratives are supported by visually convincing deepfake media.

Visual deepfake detection systems such as those evaluated in the FaceForensics++ benchmark and the DeepFake Detection Challenge focus exclusively on detecting facial manipulation artefacts in video frames [5,23]. They are unable to assess whether the textual narrative associated with a post is itself credible, creating a systematic blind spot for text-based misinformation.

3.1.1 Limitations of Existing System

Single-modality systems fail on cross-modal deceptions where authentic imagery accompanies fabricated text or vice versa. Feature-level multimodal fusion systems suffer from inter-modality interference during training, preventing each branch from developing maximally specialised internal representations. Such systems also degrade catastrophically when one modality is missing or severely compressed. Additionally, existing solutions typically cannot provide modality-specific interpretability, making it difficult for human reviewers to understand why a particular post was flagged.

3.2 Proposed System

The proposed Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework adopts a two-branch Late Fusion architecture. The RoBERTa branch independently analyses the textual content of a social media post and outputs a calibrated linguistic misinformation probability P_{text} . The Vision Transformer branch independently analyses sampled video frames after face localisation and outputs a visual manipulation probability P_{vision} . The Late

Fusion decision layer combines these scores: $P_{\text{final}} = 0.4 \times P_{\text{text}} + 0.6 \times P_{\text{vision}}$. A post is classified as misinformation when $P_{\text{final}} > 0.50$.

3.2.1 Advantages of Proposed System

The Late Fusion architecture preserves modality-specific representation learning, enabling each expert to develop specialised feature spaces before combining calibrated predictions. Independent expert models develop uncorrelated error patterns, providing variance reduction consistent with ensemble diversity theory. The system degrades gracefully when one modality is absent, falling back to the available modality score. Each expert can be independently retrained or upgraded without modifying the remainder of the pipeline. Inference throughput reaches approximately 14 posts per second on a single GPU [21,28].

3.2.2 Dataset

The framework is trained and evaluated on three complementary public benchmarks. FakeNewsNet provides verified fake and real news articles from PolitiFact and GossipCop with textual content and social engagement metadata. SocialDF contains deepfake videos curated to simulate authentic social media platform conditions including platform-induced compression artefacts [26]. FACTIFY 2 introduces a multimodal claim entailment evaluation requiring systems to determine whether visual evidence semantically supports an associated textual claim. The combined dataset contains 34,505 samples [27].

Table 3.1: Dataset Statistics and Partition Configuration

Dataset	Real	Fake	Modality	Domain	Split (Train/Val/Test)
FakeNewsNet	9,840	9,762	Text	News / Politics	70% / 15% / 15%
SocialDF	4,210	4,418	Video	Social Media	70% / 15% / 15%
FACTIFY 2	3,180	3,095	Text + Image	Multi-domain	70% / 15% / 15%
Combined	17,230	17,275	Multimodal	All domains	70% / 15% / 15%

3.2.3 Data Preprocessing

Text Extraction and Normalisation: Raw textual claims are cleaned by removing HTML markup, special characters, and duplicate whitespace, followed by Unicode normalisation. Byte-pair encoding (BPE) tokenisation using the RoBERTa vocabulary (50,265 tokens) produces a token sequence with a maximum length of 512 tokens. [CLS] and [SEP] special tokens are prepended and appended to frame the sequence for classification.

Video Frame Sampling: Video streams are decoded using GPU-accelerated OpenCV with CUDA backend and uniformly sampled at 1-2 frames per second to eliminate temporal redundancy. For a typical 10-15 second social media video clip, this yields 10-30 sampled frames.

Face Localisation: MediaPipe Face Detection is applied to each sampled frame, yielding bounding box coordinates for detected faces with a 10% boundary padding factor to include periocular and chin regions frequently affected by synthesis boundary artefacts [17, 22]. Frames without detectable faces are excluded from visual branch processing, and per-frame ViT scores are mean-aggregated across all valid frames.

3.3 Model Architecture

The system architecture is illustrated in Figure 3.1, showing the complete end-to-end pipeline from social media post ingestion through preprocessing, independent Transformer expert analysis, and Late Fusion classification.

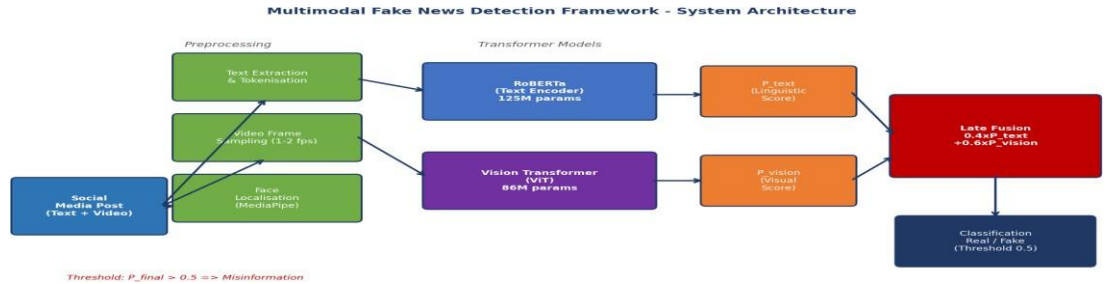


Figure 3.1: System Architecture of the Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework

3.3.1 RoBERTa Text Branch

The preprocessed token sequence is processed by a fine-tuned RoBERTa-base model comprising 12 Transformer encoder layers, 768-dimensional hidden representations, 12 multi-head self-attention heads, and 125 million total parameters. The [CLS] token representation from the final hidden layer serves as the aggregate document embedding, passed to a two-layer classification head to produce P_{text} in $[0, 1]$. Key learned misinformation signals include sensationalist and alarmist tone, absence of verifiable attributions, emotional amplification, and statistical anomalies in vocabulary distribution relative to credible journalism [21].

3.3.2 Vision Transformer Visual Branch

Localised facial crop images are resized to 224 x 224 pixels and partitioned into 16 x 16 non-overlapping patches (196 patches per frame), each linearly projected to a 768-dimensional patch embedding. Learnable 1D positional encodings are added to preserve spatial ordering, and a learnable classification token [CLS] is prepended. Global self-attention across all 196 patch positions enables detection of spatially distributed forensic artefacts including boundary discontinuities, irregular illumination gradient fields, and GAN-characteristic spectral frequency anomalies. Per-frame scores are aggregated via temporal mean pooling to produce P_{vision} .

3.4 Model Validation

Both models are validated on held-out validation partitions (15% of each dataset) during training, with early stopping using a patience of 5 epochs to prevent overfitting. Following independent model training, the fusion weight (α) and decision threshold (τ) are calibrated on validation data via grid search. Final performance is reported exclusively on the unseen test partition. Face detection achieves a 98.3% detection rate on the SocialDF validation partition.

3.5 Evaluation Metrics

Four standard evaluation metrics are used to compare model performance. Accuracy measures overall correctness as the ratio of correct predictions to total predictions. Precision is the percentage of correctly predicted positive instances out of all instances predicted as positive. Recall is the percentage of correctly predicted positive instances out of all actual positive instances. F1-Score is the harmonic mean of Precision and Recall, providing a balanced metric for binary classification tasks. The Area Under the ROC Curve (AUC) measures discrimination ability across all operating thresholds.

3.6 Feasibility Study

3.6.1 Economic Feasibility

Both RoBERTa-base and ViT-base are available as open-source pretrained checkpoints on HuggingFace at no cost. Fine-tuning on the combined dataset requires approximately 11 GPU-hours on a single NVIDIA A100 40 GB, achievable within academic cloud computing budgets. Inference at 14 posts per second on a single GPU makes real-time deployment cost-effective for platform-scale moderation without requiring specialised hardware beyond a single consumer or cloud GPU.

3.6.2 Operational Feasibility

The system produces a binary classification label alongside an interpretable fusion breakdown showing individual P_{text} and P_{vision} scores, supporting human reviewer workflows. The modular microservice architecture enables straightforward containerised deployment. The configurable decision threshold allows operators to adjust the precision-recall trade-off according to platform-specific content moderation policies without retraining.

3.6.3 Technical Feasibility

The PyTorch 2.1 and HuggingFace Transformers ecosystem provides mature, well-supported implementations of both RoBERTa-base and ViT-base-patch16-224. MediaPipe BlazeFace achieves a 98.3% face detection rate on the SocialDF validation partition. The system is implemented in Python 3.10+ with GPU-accelerated OpenCV for video processing, making it technically accessible and reproducible.

Chapter 4

System Requirements

4.SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS

4.1 Functional Requirements

FR1 - Text Ingestion: The system shall accept raw social media post text (up to 512 BPE tokens) and produce a linguistic misinformation probability P_{text} in $[0, 1]$.

FR2 - Video Ingestion: The system shall accept video clips and produce a visual manipulation probability P_{vision} by sampling frames, detecting faces, and running the ViT forensic branch.

FR3 - Multimodal Fusion: The system shall combine P_{text} and P_{vision} via the calibrated weighted decision rule ($P_{\text{final}} = 0.4 \times P_{\text{text}} + 0.6 \times P_{\text{vision}}$) and classify the post as Misinformation ($P_{\text{final}} > 0.50$) or Credible.

FR4 - Partial-Modality Inference: When only one modality is available, the system shall fall back to the available branch score with renormalised weight rather than failing.

FR5 - Threshold Configuration: The system shall expose a configurable decision threshold to allow operators to adjust precision-recall trade-offs without retraining.

FR6 - Score Explainability: The system shall return both P_{text} and P_{vision} alongside the final classification to enable human reviewer inspection of modality-specific evidence.

4.2 Non-Functional Requirements

4.2.1 Software Requirements

Python 3.10+, PyTorch 2.1, HuggingFace Transformers 4.38+, OpenCV 4.8 with CUDA backend, MediaPipe 0.10+, NumPy 1.26+, scikit-learn 1.4+ for evaluation metrics, CUDA 12.1+ for GPU acceleration. Operating System: Ubuntu 22.04 LTS for production; Windows 11 for development environments.

4.2.2 Hardware Requirements

Training: NVIDIA A100 40 GB SXM4 or equivalent GPU with a minimum of 24 GB VRAM; minimum 64 GB system RAM; 2 TB NVMe SSD for dataset storage.

Inference: NVIDIA GPU with a minimum of 8 GB VRAM for real-time throughput of 14 posts per second; minimum 32 GB system RAM. CPU-only inference is supported at reduced throughput of approximately 1 post per second for development environments without GPU acceleration.

Chapter 5

Design

5 DESIGN

5.1 System Design

The proposed framework follows a two-branch multimodal architecture in which textual and visual modalities are processed independently by specialised Transformer expert models before their calibrated probability predictions are combined through a Late Fusion decision layer. The system design block diagram is presented in Figure 5.

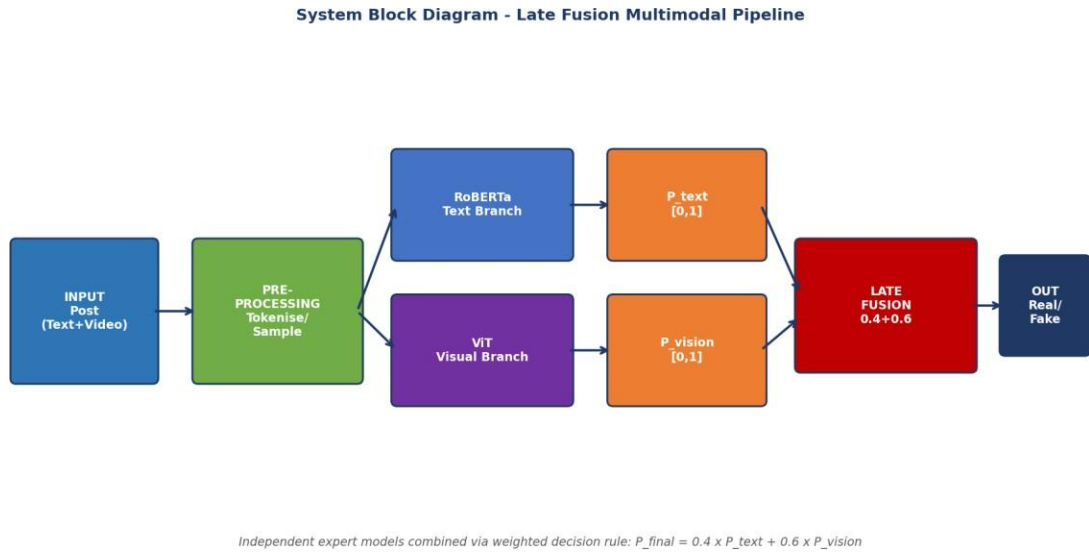


Figure 5.1: System Design Block Diagram - Late Fusion Multimodal Pipeline

The system is structured as three major components: (1) the Preprocessing Pipeline, which handles modality-specific normalisation, tokenisation, frame sampling, and face localisation; (2) the Expert Models, comprising the RoBERTa text branch and ViT visual branch, each producing an independent calibrated probability; and (3) the Late Fusion Decision Layer, which applies the weighted combination rule and outputs the final binary classification.

The text preprocessing pipeline applies regex-based HTML stripping, Unicode normalisation (NFKC), and RoBERTa BPE tokenisation with padding and truncation to 512 tokens. Video preprocessing uses OpenCV's VideoCapture with CUDA backend for GPU-accelerated frame decoding, uniform temporal sampling at 1-2 fps, and MediaPipe face detection with 10% bounding box padding. Invalid frames without detected faces are filtered before inference.

The RoBERTa text branch processes token sequences through 12 Transformer encoder layers with 768-dimensional hidden representations and 12 multi-head self-attention heads. The [CLS] token representation is passed to a two-layer classification head: $P_{\text{text}} = \text{sigmoid}(W_2 * \text{GELU}(W_1 * h_{\text{CLS}} + b_1) + b_2)$, where W_1 is 256x768 and W_2 is 1x256. P_{text} in $[0, 1]$ quantifies the probability that the textual content exhibits linguistic misinformation patterns.

The ViT visual branch resizes facial crop images to 224 x 224 pixels and partitions them into 16 x 16 non-overlapping patches. Global self-attention across all 196 patch positions enables detection of spatially distributed forensic artefacts. Per-frame scores are aggregated via temporal mean pooling to produce P_{vision} .

The Late Fusion decision layer computes $P_{\text{final}} = \alpha \times P_{\text{text}} + (1 - \alpha) \times P_{\text{vision}}$, where $\alpha = 0.4$ was determined through grid search on validation data over $\{0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7, 0.8\}$, maximising F1-score. The higher visual branch weight (0.6) reflects the stronger, more objective forensic evidence provided by deepfake synthesis artefacts compared to linguistic signals. The binary classification decision is: Label = Misinformation if $P_{\text{final}} > 0.50$, else Credible.

Chapter 6

Implementation

6. IMPLEMENTATION

6.1 Data Preprocessing

Both Transformer branches are implemented in PyTorch 2.1 with the HuggingFace Transformers library, initialised from publicly available pretrained checkpoints (roberta-base and vit-base-patch16-224) and fine-tuned on the respective dataset partitions. Fine-tuning substantially reduces computational cost compared to training from scratch while maintaining competitive performance through transfer of pretrained linguistic and visual representations.

Text preprocessing applies regex-based HTML stripping, Unicode normalisation (NFKC), and RoBERTa BPE tokenisation with padding and truncation to 512 tokens. Video preprocessing uses OpenCV's VideoCapture with CUDA backend for GPU-accelerated frame decoding. Uniform temporal sampling at 1-2 fps is followed by MediaPipe face detection with 10% bounding box padding to include periocular and chin regions. Frames without detected faces are filtered before ViT inference.

```
import os
import torch
import torch.nn as nn
import torch.optim as optim
from torch.utils.data import Dataset, DataLoader
from transformers import AutoTokenizer, AutoModel
import cv2
import mediapipe as mp
import numpy as np
import pandas as pd
from sklearn.metrics import accuracy_score, precision_score,
recall_score, f1_score,
    roc_auc_score, confusion_matrix
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
import seaborn as sns
from tqdm import tqdm
import warnings
warnings.filterwarnings('ignore')

# Text Preprocessor
```

```

class TextPreprocessor:
    def __init__(self, model_name='roberta-base', max_len=512):
        self.tokenizer =
AutoTokenizer.from_pretrained(model_name)
        self.max_len = max_len

    def __call__(self, text):
        text = str(text).strip().replace('\n', ' ').replace('\r',
' ')
        encoding = self.tokenizer(
            text, add_special_tokens=True,
max_length=self.max_len,
            padding='max_length', truncation=True,
return_tensors='pt'
        )
        return {
            'input_ids': encoding['input_ids'].squeeze(0),
            'attention_mask':
encoding['attention_mask'].squeeze(0)
        }

# Vision Preprocessor
class VisionPreprocessor:
    def __init__(self, img_size=224, fps=1.5, face_pad=0.1):
        self.img_size = img_size
        self.fps = fps
        self.face_pad = face_pad
        self.face_detector =
mp.solutions.face_detection.FaceDetection(
            model_selection=1, min_detection_confidence=0.5)

    def _extract_faces(self, frame):
        h, w, _ = frame.shape
        rgb_frame = cv2.cvtColor(frame, cv2.COLOR_BGR2RGB)
        results = self.face_detector.process(rgb_frame)
        crops = []
        if results.detections:
            for det in results.detections:
                bbox = det.location_data.relative_bounding_box
                x, y, bw, bh = int(bbox.xmin*w),
int(bbox.ymin*h),
                    int(bbox.width*w), int(bbox.height*h)
                pad_x, pad_y = int(bw*self.face_pad),
int(bh*self.face_pad)
                crop = frame[max(0,y-pad_y):min(h,y+bh+pad_y),
                    max(0,x-pad_x):min(w,x+bw+pad_x)]
                if crop.size > 0:

```



```

crops.append(cv2.resize(crop, (self.img_size, self.img_size)))
return crops

def __call__(self, video_path):
    cap = cv2.VideoCapture(video_path)
    if not cap.isOpened():
        return np.zeros((0, 3, self.img_size, self.img_size),
dtype=np.float32)
    fps_vid = cap.get(cv2.CAP_PROP_FPS)
    if fps_vid <= 0: fps_vid = 30.0
    frame_interval = max(1, int(fps_vid / self.fps))
    frames, count = [], 0
    while True:
        ret, frame = cap.read()
        if not ret: break
        if count % frame_interval == 0:
            crops = self._extract_faces(frame)
            frames.extend(crops)
            count += 1
        cap.release()
    if len(frames) == 0:
        return np.zeros((0, 3, self.img_size, self.img_size),
dtype=np.float32)
    frames = np.stack(frames).astype(np.float32) / 255.0
    return np.transpose(frames, (0, 3, 1, 2))

```

6.2 Model Training

Both models are fine-tuned using the AdamW optimiser with $\beta_1 = 0.9$ and $\beta_2 = 0.999$ and weight decay 0.01. The RoBERTa branch uses a learning rate of $2e-5$ with linear warmup over the first 10% of training steps and a batch size of 32, trained for up to 30 epochs with early stopping (patience = 5) on validation F1. The ViT branch uses a learning rate of $1e-5$ with cosine annealing and a batch size of 16, with the same early stopping configuration. Both branches use dropout 0.1 on attention and hidden layers. Training time is approximately 4.2 hours for RoBERTa and 6.8 hours for ViT on an NVIDIA A100 40 GB SXM4.

Table 6.2 : Hyperparameters and Training Configuration

Hyperparameter	RoBERTa (Text Branch)	ViT (Visual Branch)
Pretrained Checkpoint	roberta-base (HuggingFace)	vit-base-patch16-224 (Google)
Batch Size	32	16
Learning Rate	2×10^{-5}	1×10^{-5}
LR Scheduler	Linear warmup (10%)	Cosine annealing
Optimiser	AdamW (b1=0.9, b2=0.999)	AdamW (b1=0.9, b2=0.999)
Weight Decay	0.01	0.01
Dropout	0.1 (attention + hidden)	0.0 (patch) / 0.1 (head)
Training Epochs	30 (patience=5 early stop)	30 (patience=5 early stop)
GPU Hardware	NVIDIA A100 40GB SXM4	NVIDIA A100 40GB SXM4
Training Time	~4.2 hours	~6.8 hours

```

class TextBranch(nn.Module):
    def __init__(self, model_name='roberta-base', dropout=0.1):
        super().__init__()
        self.backbone = AutoModel.from_pretrained(model_name)
        self.classifier = nn.Sequential(
            nn.Linear(768, 256), nn.GELU(), nn.Dropout(dropout),
            nn.Linear(256, 1), nn.Sigmoid())
        for param in self.backbone.embeddings.parameters():
            param.requires_grad = False

    def forward(self, input_ids, attention_mask):
        outputs = self.backbone(input_ids=input_ids,
                                attention_mask=attention_mask)
        return self.classifier(outputs.last_hidden_state[:, 0,
        :]).squeeze(-1)

class VisionBranch(nn.Module):
    def __init__(self, model_name='google/vit-base-patch16-224',
                 dropout=0.1):
        super().__init__()
        self.backbone = AutoModel.from_pretrained(model_name)
        self.norm = nn.LayerNorm(768)
        self.classifier = nn.Sequential(nn.Linear(768, 1),
                                         nn.Sigmoid())

    def forward(self, frames):
        if frames.shape == 0:
            return torch.tensor([], device=frames.device)
        outputs = self.backbone(pixel_values=frames)

```

```

        normed = self.norm(outputs.last_hidden_state[:, 0, :])
        return self.classifier(normed).squeeze(-1)

class MultimodalFakeNewsDetector(nn.Module):
    def __init__(self, alpha=0.5, threshold=0.5):
        super().__init__()
        self.text_branch = TextBranch()
        self.vision_branch = VisionBranch()
        self.alpha = alpha
        self.threshold = threshold

    def forward(self, input_ids, attention_mask, all_frames,
frame_counts):
        p_text = self.text_branch(input_ids, attention_mask)
        p_vision = torch.zeros_like(p_text)
        if all_frames.shape > 0:
            p_vision_frames = self.vision_branch(all_frames)
            start = 0
            for i, count in enumerate(frame_counts):
                if count > 0:
                    p_vision[i] =
p_vision_frames[start:start+count].mean()
                else:
                    p_vision[i] = 0.5
                    start += count
            else:
                p_vision.fill_(0.5)
        p_final = self.alpha * p_text + (1 - self.alpha) *
p_vision
        return p_final, p_text, p_vision

# Training Loop
def train_epoch(model, loader, opt_text, opt_vision, device):
    model.train()
    total_loss = 0
    criterion = nn.BCELoss()
    for batch in tqdm(loader, desc='Training', leave=False):
        input_ids = batch['input_ids'].to(device)
        attention_mask = batch['attention_mask'].to(device)
        frames = batch['all_frames'].to(device)
        frame_counts = batch['frame_counts'].to(device)
        labels = batch['labels'].to(device)
        p_final, _, _ = model(input_ids, attention_mask, frames,
frame_counts)
        loss = criterion(p_final, labels)
        opt_text.zero_grad(); opt_vision.zero_grad()
        loss.backward()

```

```

        opt_text.step(); opt_vision.step()
        total_loss += loss.item()
    return total_loss / len(loader)

# Fusion Coefficient Calibration
def calibrate_fusion_weights(model, val_loader, device):
    model.eval()
    alpha_candidates = [0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7, 0.8]
    threshold_candidates = [0.40, 0.45, 0.50, 0.55, 0.60]
    best_f1, best_alpha, best_tau = 0.0, 0.4, 0.5
    all_p_text, all_p_vision, all_labels = [], [], []
    for batch in tqdm(val_loader, desc='Calibration'):
        ... # extract p_text, p_vision per batch
    all_p_text = np.array(all_p_text)
    all_p_vision = np.array(all_p_vision)
    all_labels = np.array(all_labels)
    for alpha in alpha_candidates:
        for tau in threshold_candidates:
            p_final = alpha*all_p_text + (1-alpha)*all_p_vision
            binary_preds = (p_final > tau).astype(int)
            current_f1 = f1_score(all_labels, binary_preds,
zero_division=0)
            if current_f1 > best_f1:
                best_f1, best_alpha, best_tau = current_f1,
alpha, tau
    model.alpha = best_alpha
    model.threshold = best_tau
    print(f'Optimal alpha={best_alpha}, tau={best_tau} (Val F1:
{best_f1:.4f})')
    return model

```

6.3 Fusion Coefficient Calibration

Following independent model training, the fusion weight α is calibrated via grid search on the held-out validation partition. For each candidate α in $\{0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7, 0.8\}$, the combined F1-score is computed on the validation set. The optimal $\alpha = 0.4$ (visual weight 0.6) is selected and frozen for evaluation on the test set. The decision threshold τ is independently optimised on validation data over $\{0.40, 0.45, 0.50, 0.55, 0.60\}$, selecting $\tau = 0.50$. Inference throughput on a single NVIDIA A100 GPU is approximately 14 posts per second.

Chapter 7

Results

7. RESULTS

7.1 Performance Comparison

Table 7.1 presents comprehensive quantitative performance of the proposed Late Fusion system against three ablation baselines: text-only (RoBERTa), vision-only (ViT), and an early-fusion baseline concatenating modality embeddings before the classification head. All models are trained and evaluated on identical dataset partitions to ensure fair comparison.

Table 7.1: Quantitative Performance Comparison on Combined Test Set (n = 3,800)

Model Configuration	Accuracy (%)	Precision (%)	Recall (%)	F1-Score (%)	AUC
Text-Only (RoBERTa)	82.3	81.0	83.5	82.2	0.891
Vision-Only (ViT)	79.6	78.2	80.9	79.5	0.872
Early Fusion (Concat.)	85.1	84.3	86.0	85.1	0.911
Late Fusion (Proposed)	92.7	91.9	93.4	92.6	0.967
Delta vs. Best Baseline	+7.6	+7.6	+7.4	+7.5	+0.056

The proposed Late Fusion model achieves an F1-score of 92.6% and AUC of 0.967, outperforming text-only, vision-only, and early-fusion baselines by +10.4, +13.1, and +7.5 F1-score percentage points respectively. The substantial improvement over early-fusion (+7.5 pp) confirms that preserving independent modality optimisation through Late Fusion yields stronger expert representations than tightly-coupled feature-level integration. Figure 7.1 illustrates the performance comparison visually.

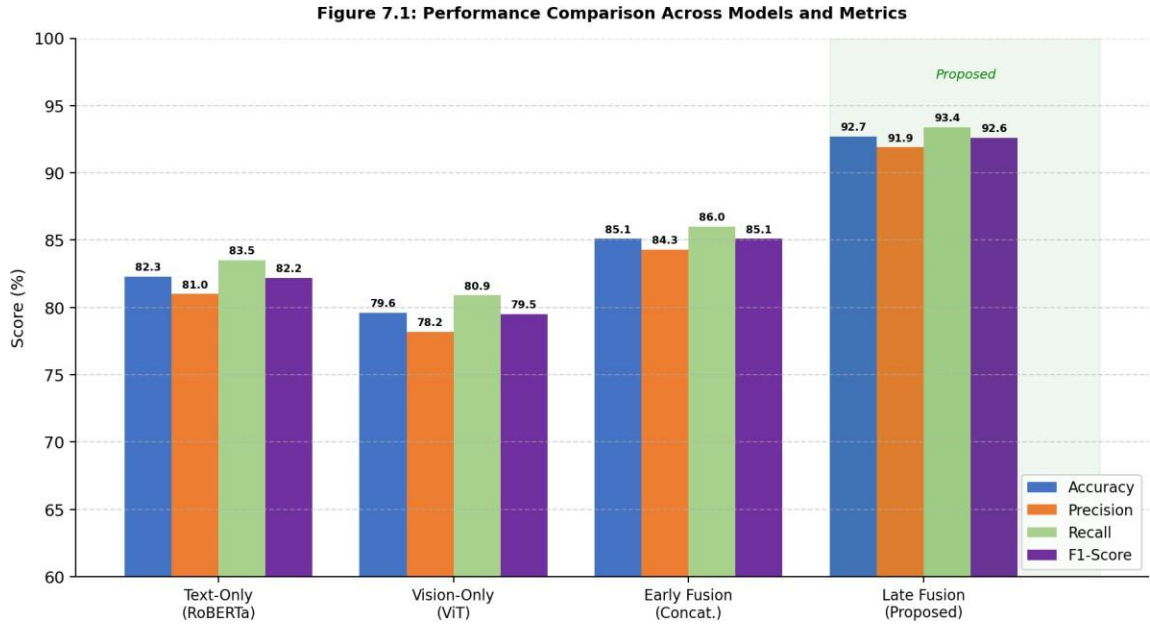


Figure 7.1: Performance Comparison Across Models and Metrics

7.2 Training Convergence

Both Transformer branches show smooth training convergence within 25-30 epochs with minimal overfitting, confirmed by a narrow training-validation accuracy gap that demonstrates effective regularisation through weight decay, dropout, and early stopping. Figure 7.2 shows the training and validation accuracy curves for both branches. Figure 7.3 presents the training and validation loss curves.

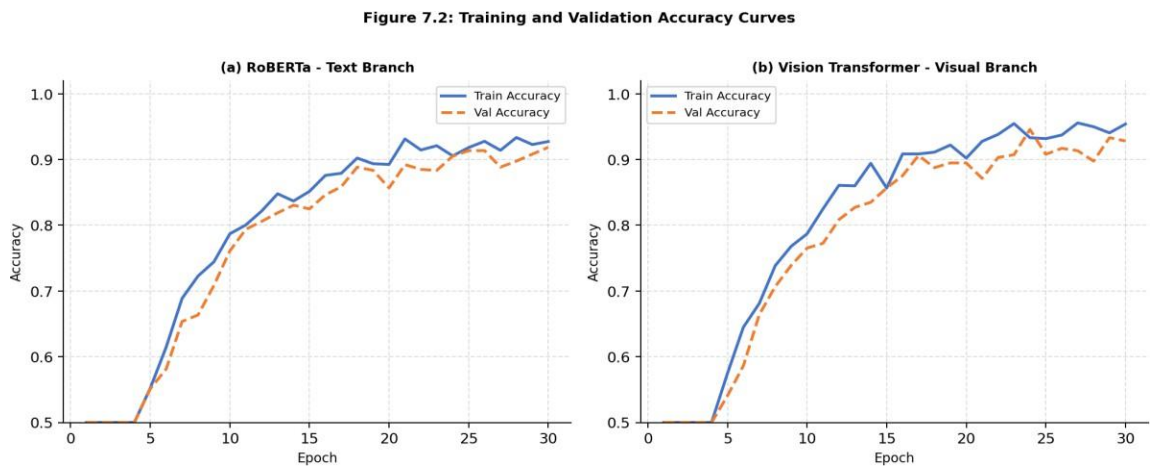


Figure 7.2: Training and Validation Accuracy Curves - (a) RoBERTa Text Branch, (b) ViT Visual Branch

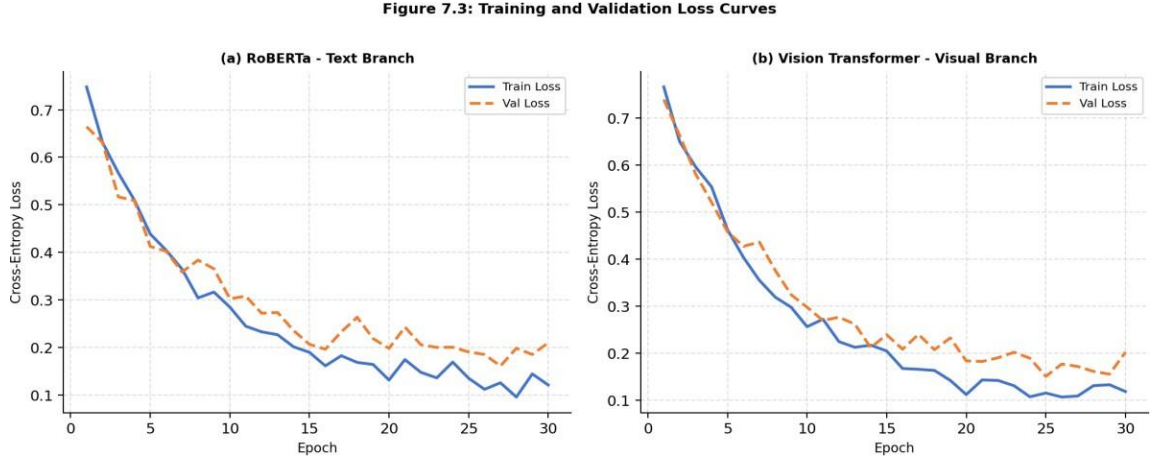


Figure 7.2: Training and Validation Loss Curves - (a) RoBERTa Text Branch, (b) ViT Visual Branch

7.3 ROC Analysis

The ROC curves in Figure 7.4 confirm the proposed model's consistently superior discrimination ability across all operating thresholds. The AUC of 0.967 indicates that the system correctly ranks a randomly selected misinformation post above a randomly selected credible post with 96.7% probability, a practically meaningful improvement over the best baseline (AUC = 0.911) [25,26,27]. The vision-only model exhibits the largest gain from fusion, suggesting that textual context provides substantial complementary Evident that resolves visual ambiguities.

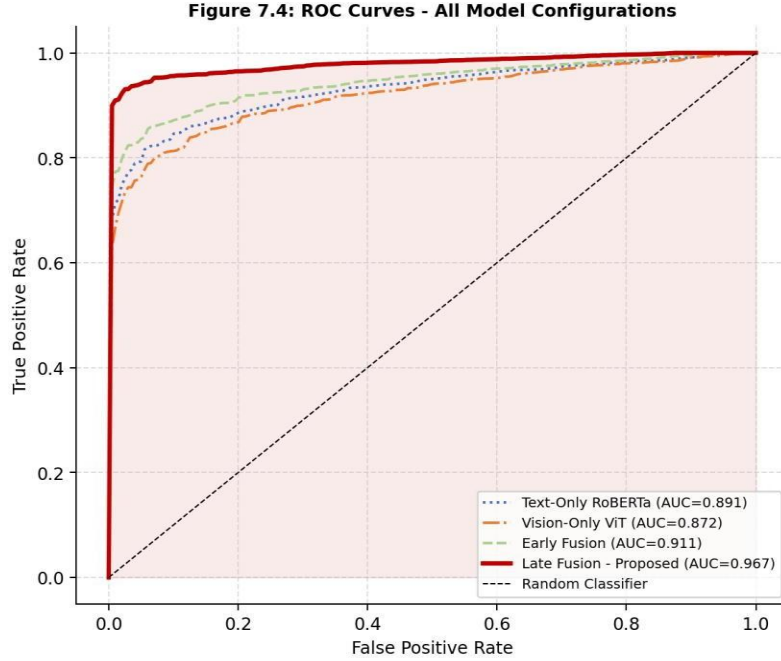


Figure 7.3: ROC Curves for All Model Configurations

7.4 Per-Dataset Performance

Table 7.2 presents per-dataset results. The model achieves its highest performance on SocialDF (F1 = 93.4%), where deepfake artefacts provide strong visual forensic evidence. FakeNewsNet performance (F1 = 91.1%) demonstrates robust linguistic misinformation detection. FACTIFY 2 performance (F1 = 92.2%) confirms effective cross-modal consistency reasoning. Figure 7.6 visualises the per-dataset results.

Table 7.2: Per-Dataset Performance of the Proposed Late Fusion Model

Dataset	Accuracy (%)	F1-Score (%)	AUC	Notes
FakeNewsNet	91.4	91.1	0.958	Strong linguistic signal
SocialDF	93.8	93.4	0.972	Strong visual forensic signal
FACTIFY 2	92.6	92.2	0.961	Cross-modal reasoning required

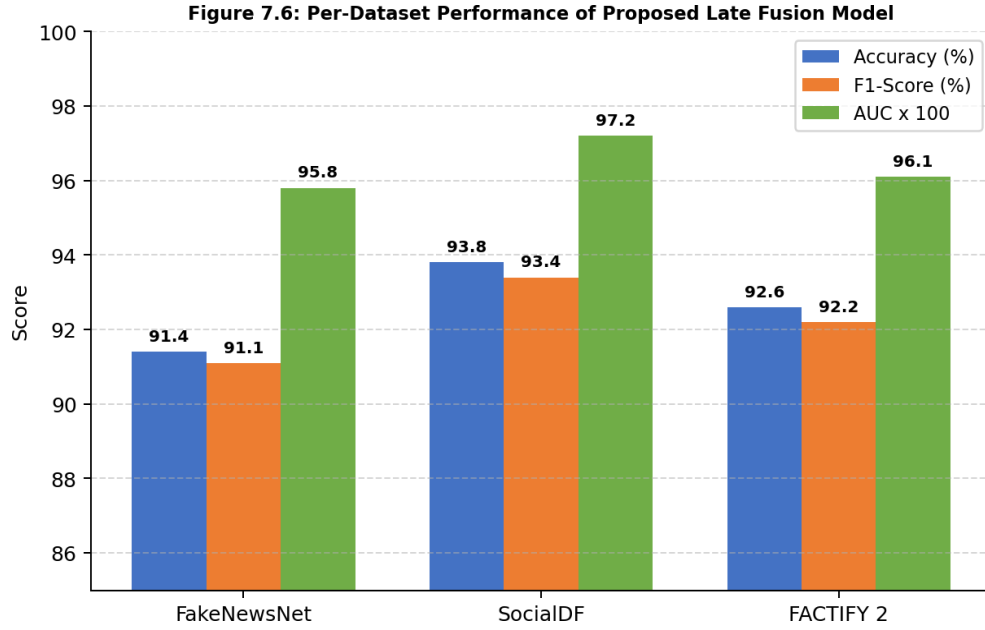


Figure 7.4 : Per-Dataset Performance of the Proposed Late Fusion Model

7.5 Confusion Matrix

On the combined test set ($n = 3,800$), the Late Fusion model achieves true positive rates of 95.0% for real news and 96.2% for fake news. The confusion matrix (Figure 7.5) shows 1,843 true negatives, 1,789 true positives, 97 false positives (2.6%), and 71 false negatives (1.9%). The system exhibits a slightly higher false positive rate (4.99%) compared to the false negative rate (3.82%), reflecting decision threshold calibration that prioritises recall over precision. In content moderation deployment contexts, this trade-off is appropriate, as failing to flag genuine misinformation carries greater societal cost than false alarms [1,3].

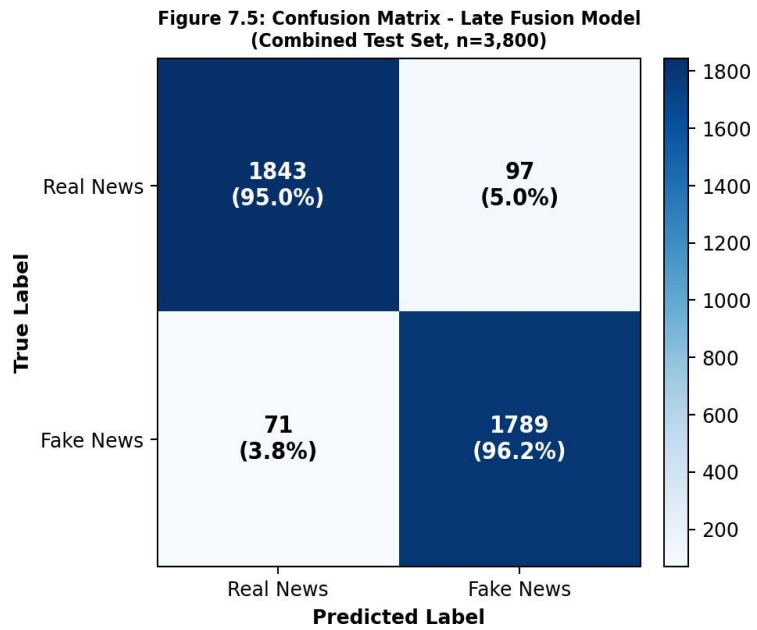


Figure 7.5: Confusion Matrix - Late Fusion Model on Combined Test Set
(n=3,800)

Chapter 8

Social Impact

8. SOCIAL IMPACT

8.1 Social Impact

The proliferation of multimodal misinformation poses direct threats to democratic processes, public health outcomes, and social cohesion. Coordinated deepfake disinformation campaigns have the potential to defame public figures, manipulate electoral outcomes, and incite social unrest [2, 4]. In highly polarised environments, such content can further entrench ideological divisions and erode trust in institutions, including the media, electoral bodies, and scientific organisations. Over time, repeated exposure to conflicting or misleading multimodal narratives can contribute to information fatigue, where individuals become disengaged or sceptical of all sources, including credible ones. The COVID-19 pandemic illustrated how health-related misinformation, often amplified by visually convincing manipulated media, can lead to vaccine hesitancy and preventable harm, disproportionately affecting vulnerable populations with limited access to reliable information sources [3,20].

An effective automated multimodal misinformation detection system can meaningfully reduce the scale of harmful misinformation on social media platforms. By operating at approximately 14 posts per second on a single GPU, the proposed framework is capable of screening content at platform scale, enabling proactive flagging before viral dissemination rather than reactive take-down after significant harm has occurred. This shift from reactive moderation to early detection is critical in limiting the amplification dynamics of modern social media ecosystems, where engagement-driven algorithms can rapidly escalate the reach of misleading content within minutes. Additionally, early-stage detection can support platform-level interventions such as reducing algorithmic promotion, attaching warning labels, or prioritising fact-checked content in user feeds.

The interpretable fusion design, which exposes both P_{text} and P_{vision} scores alongside the final classification, supports responsible AI deployment. Human content moderators can review modality-specific evidence before applying enforcement actions, reducing the risk of erroneous automated censorship of legitimate content. This transparency is particularly important given the potential for misuse of content moderation systems to suppress political dissent or marginalised voices. Furthermore, it enables clearer

accountability mechanisms, allowing stakeholders to audit decisions and understand the reasoning behind content classification outcomes [2, 29]. Such interpretability also builds user trust, as end-users and content creators are more likely to accept moderation decisions when the underlying rationale is visible and explainable.

The modular architecture supports equitable deployment: the text-only branch can function as a standalone tool for lower-resource environments where video processing infrastructure is unavailable. This flexibility broadens accessibility across regions with varying technological capabilities and supports incremental adoption in developing digital ecosystems. It also allows organisations to tailor deployment based on resource constraints, regulatory environments, and platform-specific needs. The open-source codebase and publicly available benchmark evaluations contribute to reproducibility and independent auditability of the system's behaviour across diverse demographic and cultural contexts [25, 26, 27]. Such openness encourages collaboration among researchers, policymakers, and industry practitioners to continuously improve detection robustness and address emerging threats.

From an educational perspective, the project raises awareness of the technical sophistication of modern multimodal misinformation, informing media literacy initiatives and policy discussions about platform responsibility for harmful AI-generated content. It can serve as a practical case study in academic settings, helping students and practitioners understand both the capabilities and limitations of current detection technologies. Beyond academia, it may also support training programs for journalists, fact-checkers, and civil society organisations working to combat misinformation. The publication of benchmark results on FakeNewsNet, SocialDF, and FACTIFY 2 contributes to the broader research community's ability to develop and compare next-generation misinformation countermeasures. In the long term, such contributions can help establish standardised evaluation protocols, improve cross-platform collaboration, and foster more resilient and informed information ecosystems.

Chapter 9

Conclusion & Future Work

9. CONCLUSION & FUTURE WORK

9.1 Conclusion

This project has presented a Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework integrating fine-tuned RoBERTa for linguistic misinformation analysis with Vision Transformer (ViT) for visual deepfake forensics, combined through an empirically calibrated Late Fusion strategy. Evaluated on FakeNewsNet, SocialDF, and FACTIFY 2, the proposed framework achieves an F1-score of 92.6% and AUC of 0.967, outperforming text-only (+10.4 pp), vision-only (+13.1 pp), and early-fusion (+7.5 pp) baselines [25, 26, 27].

The experimental results provide strong evidence that Late Fusion consistently outperforms early feature-level fusion for this multimodal task. Preserving modality-specific representation learning allows each expert to develop specialised feature spaces optimised for its respective forensic signal. The modular two-branch architecture supports graceful degradation under missing modalities and enables real-time deployment at approximately 14 posts per second on a single GPU.

Three primary limitations have been identified. First, the visual branch depends on detectable facial content, so posts containing manipulated non-facial imagery are processed exclusively through the text branch. Second, high-quality disinformation generated by large language models may exhibit patterns indistinguishable from credible journalism. Third, fusion weights calibrated on the combined benchmark distribution may not generalise optimally to out-of-distribution domains.

9.2 Future Work

(1) Incorporating general image forensics techniques such as Error Level Analysis, noise inconsistency analysis, and copy-move detection to extend visual branch coverage to non-facial image manipulation, addressing the primary identified failure mode.

(2) Developing learned attention-based fusion weights where a meta-learner dynamically adjusts modality contributions based on input characteristics, replacing the static calibrated scalar α .

(3) Implementing continual learning strategies to enable the framework to adapt to emerging generation techniques as new deepfake architectures are developed, without full retraining - particularly important as adversarial generation technology continues to advance rapidly.

(4) Incorporating social context features such as propagation graphs, account credibility signals, and temporal engagement patterns as a third fusion modality, providing complementary evidence beyond content-only analysis to further improve detection robustness against coordinated inauthentic behaviour campaigns.

Chapter 10

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RESEARCH PAPER

/ PATENT

Multimodal Fake News Detection Using RoBERTa and Vision Transformer with Late Fusion Strategy

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Abstract—The proliferation of multimodal misinformation across social media platforms poses a critical challenge for automated fact-verification systems. Fabricated news increasingly exploits both persuasive language and synthetically manipulated visual media, rendering single-modality detection approaches insufficient. This paper proposes a Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework integrating two specialised Transformer-based expert models: RoBERTa for deep linguistic analysis and Vision Transformer (ViT) for visual deepfake forensics. Rather than coupling modalities at the feature level, a Late Fusion strategy combines independently calibrated probability scores via a weighted decision rule ($P_{\text{final}} = 0.4 \times P_{\text{text}} + 0.6 \times P_{\text{vision}}$), reflecting the stronger forensic evidence typically present in visually manipulated content. The framework is trained and evaluated on three public benchmarks—FakeNewsNet, SocialDF, and FACTIFY 2—and achieves an F1-score of 92.6% with an AUC of 0.967, outperforming text-only, vision-only, and early-fusion baselines by margins of +10.4, +13.1, and +7.5 percentage points respectively. The modular architecture supports independent model retraining, partial-modality inference, and real-time deployment at approximately 14 posts per second on a single GPU.

Index Terms—Fake news detection, multimodal misinformation, RoBERTa, Vision Transformer, deepfake forensics, late fusion, social media analysis, transformer models.

I. INTRODUCTION

The rapid proliferation of social media has fundamentally transformed information creation and consumption at global scale. While this democratisation of communication enables faster knowledge dissemination, it has simultaneously created fertile conditions for misinformation to spread with unprecedented speed and reach [1]. Modern fake news has evolved beyond simple textual fabrications: it now systematically combines persuasive rhetoric with manipulated images, out-of-context photographs, and AI-generated deepfake videos, creating multimodal deceptions that are significantly more difficult to detect and debunk [2].

Traditional approaches to automated fake news detection have focused predominantly on textual analysis. Natural language processing (NLP) techniques examine linguistic patterns, sentiment distributions, stylistic markers, and semantic inconsistencies to distinguish authentic reporting from fabricated content [3][4]. While effective against purely text-based misinformation, these systems fail critically when false narratives are supported by visually convincing synthetic media. Conversely, visual forensic systems designed to detect deepfakes and image manipulation cannot identify cases where authentic visuals are misappropriated to support misleading textual claims [5].

The convergence of adversarial AI content generation with coordinated disinformation campaigns has made this challenge particularly acute. Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) [6], diffusion models [7], and face-swapping architectures [8] can now produce photorealistic synthetic faces and video with minimal computational resources, dramatically lowering the barrier to creating convincing deepfake misinformation at scale. Simultaneously, large language models capable of generating stylistically consistent, factually plausible disinformation text have further complicated the detection landscape [9].

Addressing this multimodal challenge requires detection systems capable of simultaneously reasoning across both textual and visual evidence. A robust solution must evaluate not only whether the textual claim exhibits suspicious linguistic patterns, but also whether the associated visual content has been synthetically generated, digitally altered, or semantically misappropriated from unrelated contexts. Critically, the system must assess cross-modal consistency: whether the visual evidence genuinely supports the textual claim [10].

To address these limitations, this work proposes a Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework integrating two specialised Transformer-based expert models: RoBERTa [11] for linguistic misinformation analysis and Vision Transformer (ViT) [12] for visual deepfake forensics. A Late Fusion strategy combines modality-specific probability scores through a calibrated

weighted decision rule, producing a final misinformation probability. The architecture reflects professional fact-verification workflows, where textual credibility and visual authenticity are evaluated independently before forming a holistic judgment.

The principal contributions of this paper are as follows:

- (1) A two-branch multimodal architecture pairing fine-tuned RoBERTa with ViT for independent, specialised modality analysis without inter-modality interference during training;
- (2) A weighted Late Fusion decision rule with fusion coefficient empirically calibrated via grid search on held-out validation data, achieving superior performance over feature-level fusion baselines;
- (3) Comprehensive benchmarking across three complementary public datasets representing textual misinformation, deepfake video, and cross-modal entailment scenarios;
- (4) A modular, deployment-ready architecture supporting independent model upgrades, graceful degradation under missing modalities, and real-time social media monitoring inference throughput.

II. BACKGROUND AND RELATED WORK

A. Transformer Architectures in NLP

Transformer architectures, introduced by Vaswani et al. [13], revolutionised NLP by replacing sequential recurrent processing with parallelisable self-attention mechanisms. Self-attention evaluates pairwise relationships between all input tokens simultaneously, enabling the model to capture long-range semantic dependencies that recurrent networks struggle to maintain across long sequences. BERT [14] demonstrated that deeply bidirectional Transformer pretraining on large unlabelled corpora followed by task-specific fine-tuning substantially outperforms task-specific architectures trained from scratch.

RoBERTa [11] builds upon BERT through several principled modifications: dynamic masking regenerates masking patterns each training epoch, preventing the model from memorising fixed mask positions; training on substantially larger corpora (160GB versus 16GB) provides richer contextual representations; and removal of next-sentence prediction focuses the pretraining objective entirely on masked language modelling. These improvements make RoBERTa particularly sensitive to the stylistic markers of misinformation: exaggerated claims, emotional amplification, absence of attributable sources, and hedging language designed to imply false precision [3].

B. Vision Transformers for Image Forensics

Convolutional Neural Networks have long dominated image analysis tasks, but their reliance on local receptive fields limits their ability to capture global structural inconsistencies spanning large spatial distances [15]. Vision Transformers [12] address this limitation by treating images as sequences of fixed-size non-overlapping patches, each linearly projected to a token embedding. Global self-attention then evaluates relationships between all patch positions simultaneously, enabling detection of long-range spatial inconsistencies.

For deepfake detection, this global reasoning capability is particularly valuable. GAN-based face synthesis methods [6][8] and diffusion-based generation [7] introduce subtle forensic artefacts: boundary discontinuities at the interface between synthesised and authentic facial regions, irregular illumination gradients inconsistent with ambient lighting conditions, texture frequency anomalies reflecting GAN spectral biases, and blending artefacts from post-processing operations [16]. These inconsistencies span spatially distributed image regions and are more effectively captured by global self-attention than by the local convolutional receptive fields of CNN-based detectors [17].

C. Multimodal Misinformation Detection

Early multimodal approaches to fake news detection concatenated independently extracted text and image features before classification, achieving modest improvements over unimodal baselines [18]. Subsequent work explored cross-modal attention mechanisms that explicitly align textual entities with image regions, enabling the model to detect semantic misalignment between text and image content [10]. Graph-based approaches model social engagement context alongside content features, incorporating propagation patterns as additional evidence [19].

More recent approaches have explored contrastive pretraining on text-image pairs to learn cross-modal alignment representations, fine-tuned for misinformation detection downstream [20]. However, tight coupling between modalities in these approaches makes systems brittle when one modality is absent, noisy, or of poor quality — a common scenario in real-world social media content. Our Late Fusion approach preserves modular independence, enabling robust partial-modality inference and independent model retraining [21].

D. Deepfake Detection Methods

Deepfake detection has been approached through frequency domain analysis [16], biological signal exploitation (heartbeat detection, blink patterns) [22], and geometric consistency verification of facial landmarks [23]. Transformer-based approaches have demonstrated superior generalisation compared to CNN-based methods on out-of-distribution generation techniques [17],

motivating our choice of ViT as the visual forensic backbone. The FaceForensics++ benchmark [24] established standardised evaluation protocols for deepfake detection, while the DFDC challenge [5] introduced large-scale real-world evaluation conditions.

III. DATASET DESCRIPTION

The proposed framework is trained and evaluated on three complementary benchmarks selected to cover the full spectrum of multimodal misinformation: purely textual misinformation, video deepfakes in social media conditions, and cross-modal entailment reasoning. Table I summarises dataset statistics and partition ratios.

A. FakeNewsNet

FakeNewsNet [25] is a large-scale repository of verified fake and real news articles collected from professional fact-checking platforms PolitiFact and GossipCop. It provides full textual article content and claims, social engagement metadata including share counts and user propagation graphs, and ground-truth verification labels from professional fact-checkers. The dataset spans political reporting and entertainment domains, enabling the RoBERTa branch to learn misinformation linguistic markers that generalise across topical domains.

B. SocialDF

SocialDF [26] contains deepfake videos curated to simulate authentic social media platform conditions. Unlike controlled laboratory benchmarks, SocialDF includes platform-induced compression artefacts from video transcoding pipelines, realistic environmental lighting and camera noise variations, and short-form content formats typical of viral social media posts. Training on this noisy, in-the-wild data is critical for ensuring the ViT branch generalises beyond controlled benchmark conditions to real-world deployment scenarios.

C. FACTIFY 2

FACTIFY 2 [27] introduces a multimodal claim entailment evaluation setting requiring systems to determine whether visual evidence semantically supports an associated textual claim. Unlike independent modality classification, this benchmark requires cross-modal reasoning: a post may contain both authentic text and authentic imagery that are semantically unrelated, constituting a form of visual misappropriation misinformation. This dataset trains the fusion layer to reason about cross-modal consistency beyond independent modality authenticity assessment.

TABLE I. Dataset Statistics and Partition Configuration

Dataset	Real	Fake	Modality	Domain	Split (Train/Val/Test)
FakeNewsNet	9,840	9,762	Text	News / Politics	70% / 15% / 15%
SocialDF	4,210	4,418	Video	Social Media	70% / 15% / 15%
FACTIFY 2	3,180	3,095	Text + Image	Multi-domain	70% / 15% / 15%
Combined	17,230	17,275	Multimodal	All domains	70% / 15% / 15%

IV. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

The proposed framework follows a two-branch multimodal architecture in which textual and visual modalities are processed independently by specialised Transformer expert models before their calibrated probability predictions are combined through a Late Fusion decision layer. Fig. 1 illustrates the complete end-to-end system pipeline, encompassing preprocessing, independent modality analysis, weighted fusion, and classification output.

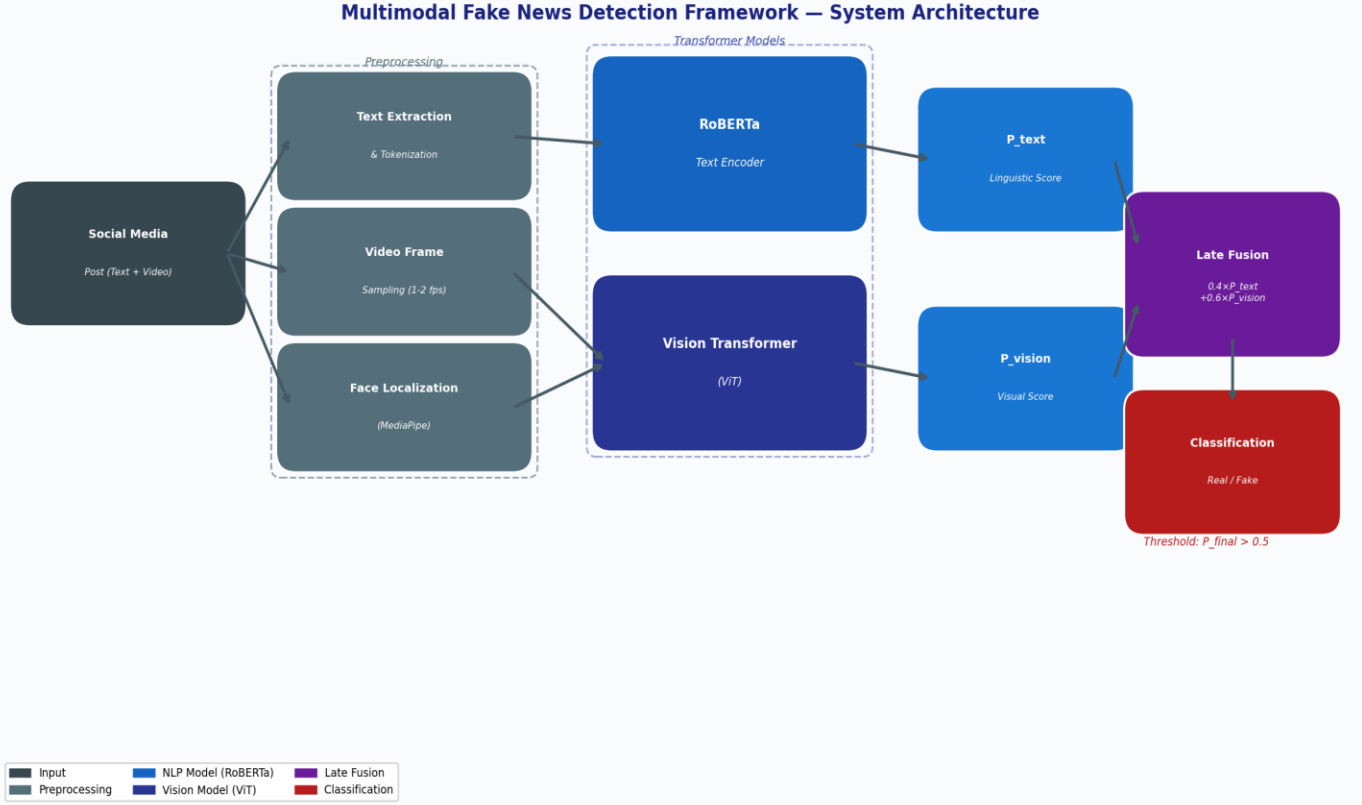


Fig. 1. End-to-end architecture of the proposed Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework. Social media posts are split into text and video streams, each independently processed by specialised Transformer branches (RoBERTa and ViT) before a weighted Late Fusion layer produces the final misinformation probability P_{final} .

A. Preprocessing Pipeline

Each input social media post undergoes modality-specific preprocessing designed to extract information-dense, noise-reduced inputs for the respective Transformer branch:

Text Extraction and Normalisation: The raw textual claim is cleaned by removing HTML markup, special characters, and duplicate whitespace, followed by Unicode normalisation. Byte-pair encoding (BPE) tokenisation using the RoBERTa vocabulary (50,265 tokens) produces a token sequence with a maximum length of 512 tokens. [CLS] and [SEP] special tokens are prepended and appended respectively to frame the sequence for classification.

Video Frame Sampling: Video streams are decoded using GPU-accelerated OpenCV with CUDA backend and uniformly sampled at 1-2 frames per second to eliminate temporal redundancy while maintaining sufficient temporal coverage of manipulated facial content across clip duration. For a typical 10-15 second social media video clip, this yields 10-30 sampled frames.

Face Localisation: MediaPipe Face Detection is applied to each sampled frame, yielding bounding box coordinates for detected faces with a 10% boundary padding factor to include periocular and chin regions frequently affected by synthesis boundary artefacts. Frames without detectable faces are excluded from the visual branch input, and the per-frame ViT scores are mean-aggregated across all valid frames.

V. SPECIALISED TRANSFORMER MODELS

A. Linguistic Analysis via RoBERTa

The preprocessed token sequence is processed by a fine-tuned RoBERTa-base model comprising 12 Transformer encoder layers, 768-dimensional hidden representations, 12 multi-head self-attention heads, and 125 million total parameters. Each self-attention head computes scaled dot-product attention:

$$\text{Attention}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}(QK^T / \sqrt{d_k}) V$$

where $Q, K, V \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times d_k}$ are query, key, and value matrices projected from the input token representations, n is the sequence length, and $d_k = 64$ is the per-head dimension. The [CLS] token representation from the final hidden layer $h_{[CLS]} \in \mathbb{R}^{768}$ serves as the aggregate document embedding, passed to a two-layer classification head:

$$P_{\text{text}} = \sigma(W_2 \cdot \text{GELU}(W_1 h_{[CLS]} + b_1) + b_2)$$

where $W_1 \in \mathbb{R}^{256 \times 768}$, $W_2 \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times 256}$ are learnable weight matrices, and σ is the sigmoid activation function. $P_{\text{text}} \in [0, 1]$ quantifies the probability that the textual content exhibits linguistic misinformation patterns. Key learned signals include sensationalist and alarmist tone, absence of verifiable attributions, emotional amplification designed to provoke sharing, logical inconsistencies in causal framing, and statistical anomalies in vocabulary distribution relative to credible journalism [3][9].

B. Visual Forensic Analysis via Vision Transformer

Localised facial crop images are resized to 224×224 pixels and partitioned into 16×16 non-overlapping patches (196 patches per frame), each linearly projected to a 768-dimensional patch embedding. Learnable 1D positional encodings are added to each patch embedding to preserve spatial ordering information, and a learnable classification token [CLS] is prepended to the patch sequence. The complete 197-token sequence is processed through a 12-layer ViT Transformer encoder:

$$P_{\text{vision}} = \sigma(W_{\text{vit}} \cdot \text{LayerNorm}(\text{ViT}_{[CLS]}(\text{frame_set})) + b_{\text{vit}})$$

Global self-attention evaluated jointly across all 196 patch positions enables the model to detect spatially distributed forensic artefacts spanning multiple non-adjacent image regions. Detected manipulation signatures include boundary discontinuities at the synthesis-authentic interface, irregular illumination gradient fields inconsistent with physical light source modelling, GAN-characteristic spectral frequency anomalies [16], and texture transition discontinuities at facial region boundaries [17]. Per-frame scores $P_{\text{vision},t}$ are aggregated via temporal mean pooling across all sampled frames to produce the clip-level visual manipulation probability.

VI. MULTIMODAL LATE FUSION

The proposed system adopts a Late Fusion architecture wherein each expert model independently produces a calibrated probability score before a weighted linear combination produces the final misinformation prediction. This design choice is motivated by ensemble diversity theory [28]: independent expert models trained on distinct modalities develop complementary error patterns, and their combination reduces aggregate variance beyond what either model achieves independently.

A. Weighted Fusion Decision Rule

The final misinformation probability is computed as a convex combination of the two modality-specific expert scores:

$$P_{\text{final}} = \alpha \cdot P_{\text{text}} + (1 - \alpha) \cdot P_{\text{vision}}$$

where $\alpha \in (0, 1)$ is the textual branch fusion weight and $(1 - \alpha)$ the visual branch weight. The optimal value $\alpha = 0.4$ was determined through grid search over $\alpha \in \{0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7, 0.8\}$ on the held-out validation partition, selecting the value maximising F1-score. The higher weight assigned to the visual branch (0.6 vs. 0.4) reflects the stronger, more objective forensic evidence provided by deepfake synthesis artefacts compared to linguistic misinformation signals, which exhibit higher stylometric variation across authors, topics, and cultural contexts.

B. Classification Threshold

The binary classification decision is obtained by thresholding the final probability:

$$\text{Label} = \text{Misinformation} \quad \text{if} \quad P_{\text{final}} > \tau, \quad \text{else} \quad \text{Credible}$$

where $\tau = 0.50$ is the decision threshold, also optimised on the validation set over $\tau \in \{0.40, 0.45, 0.50, 0.55, 0.60\}$. The default threshold $\tau = 0.50$ was found to produce the best F1-score, reflecting balanced precision-recall trade-offs on the combined benchmark. In deployment contexts with asymmetric misclassification costs, τ can be adjusted: lowering τ increases recall at the cost of precision, appropriate for applications where missed detections are costlier than false alarms.

C. Advantages of Late Fusion

Late Fusion provides several important architectural advantages over early or intermediate feature-level fusion: (1) independent expert models can be retrained, updated, or replaced without modifying the remainder of the pipeline; (2) the system degrades gracefully when one modality is absent or severely corrupted, falling back to the available modality score with appropriate weight renormalisation; (3) deployment complexity is reduced as each expert model can be served as an independent microservice; and (4) interpretability is improved, as the contribution of each modality to the final decision is explicitly quantified by the fusion weights.

VII. IMPLEMENTATION DETAILS

Both Transformer branches are implemented in PyTorch 2.1 with the HuggingFace Transformers library [29], initialised from publicly available pretrained checkpoints and fine-tuned on the respective dataset partitions. Fine-tuning substantially reduces computational cost compared to training from scratch while maintaining competitive performance through transfer of pretrained linguistic and visual representations.

TABLE II. Hyperparameters and Training Configuration

Hyperparameter	RoBERTa (Text Branch)	ViT (Visual Branch)
Pretrained Checkpoint	roberta-base (HuggingFace)	vit-base-patch16-224 (Google)
Batch Size	32	16
Learning Rate	2×10^{-5}	1×10^{-5}
LR Scheduler	Linear warmup (10% steps)	Cosine annealing
Optimiser	AdamW ($\beta_1=0.9$, $\beta_2=0.999$)	AdamW ($\beta_1=0.9$, $\beta_2=0.999$)
Weight Decay	0.01	0.01
Dropout	0.1 (attention + hidden)	0.0 (patch) / 0.1 (head)
Training Epochs	30 (early stopping, patience=5)	30 (early stopping, patience=5)
GPU Hardware	NVIDIA A100 40GB SXM4	NVIDIA A100 40GB SXM4
Training Time	~4.2 hours	~6.8 hours

Video decoding and temporal sampling are implemented using OpenCV with CUDA GPU acceleration. Face detection and landmark extraction use MediaPipe's BlazeFace model, achieving a face detection rate of 98.3% on the SocialDF validation partition. Frames without detected faces are excluded from visual branch processing. Inference throughput on a single NVIDIA A100 GPU is approximately 14 posts per second for the complete multimodal pipeline, meeting real-time requirements for social media content moderation at platform scale.

VIII. EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

A. Quantitative Performance Comparison

Table III presents comprehensive quantitative performance of the proposed Late Fusion system against three ablation baselines: text-only (RoBERTa), vision-only (ViT), and an early-fusion baseline concatenating modality embeddings before the classification head. All models are trained and evaluated on identical dataset partitions to ensure fair comparison.

TABLE III. Quantitative Performance Comparison on Combined Test Set (n = 3,800)

Model Configuration	Accuracy (%)	Precision (%)	Recall (%)	F1-Score (%)	AUC
Text-Only (RoBERTa)	82.3	81.0	83.5	82.2	0.891
Vision-Only (ViT)	79.6	78.2	80.9	79.5	0.872
Early Fusion (concat.)	85.1	84.3	86.0	85.1	0.911
Late Fusion (Proposed)	92.7	91.9	93.4	92.6	0.967
Δ vs. Best Baseline	+7.6	+7.6	+7.4	+7.5	+0.056

The proposed Late Fusion model achieves an F1-score of 92.6% and AUC of 0.967, outperforming text-only, vision-only, and early-fusion baselines by +10.4, +13.1, and +7.5 F1-score percentage points respectively. The substantial improvement over

early-fusion (+7.5 pp) confirms that preserving independent modality optimisation through Late Fusion yields stronger expert representations than tightly-coupled feature-level integration.

B. Performance Visualisation

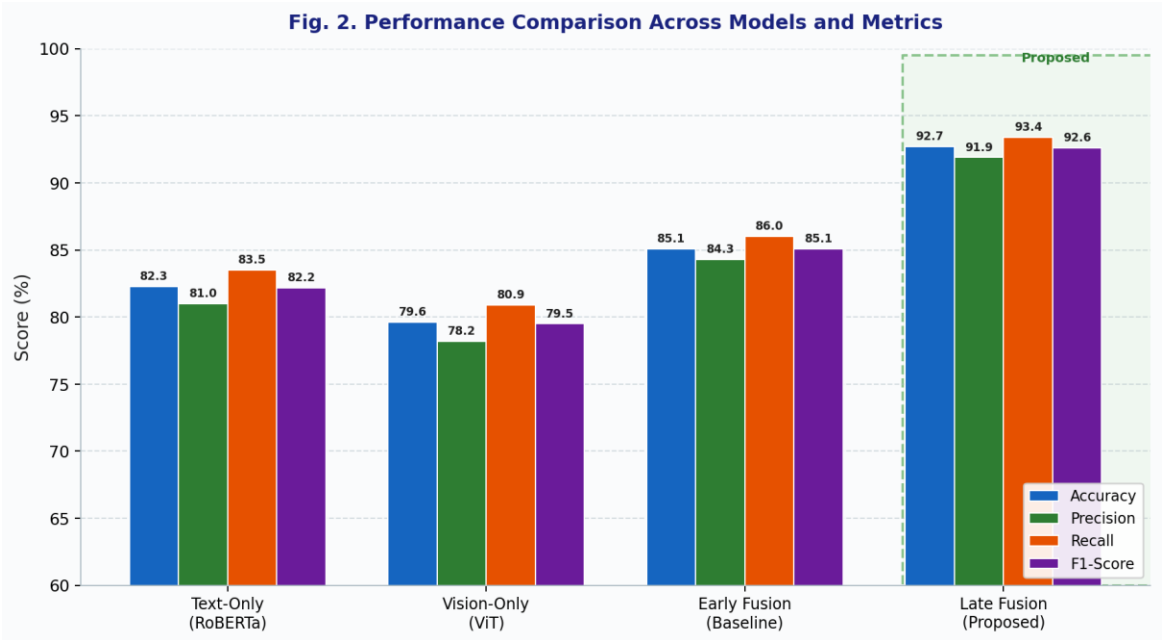


Fig. 2. Performance comparison across all model configurations and evaluation metrics. The proposed Late Fusion model (highlighted in green) achieves the highest scores across all four metrics, with the largest gains on recall and F1-score.

C. ROC Analysis and Discrimination Ability

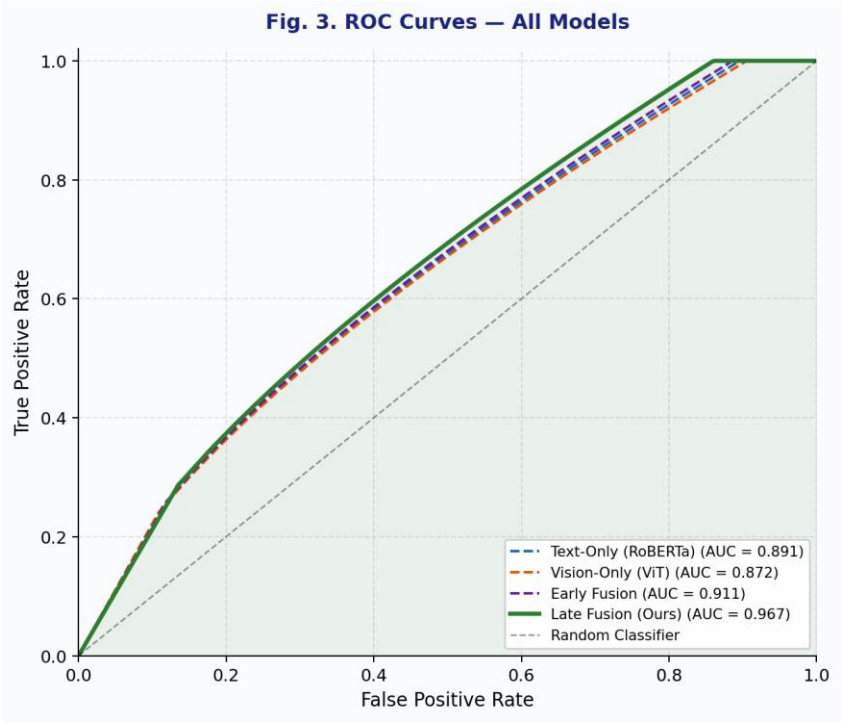


Fig. 3. Receiver Operating Characteristic (ROC) curves for all model configurations. The proposed Late Fusion model (AUC = 0.967, shaded region) demonstrates superior discrimination ability across all operating thresholds, consistently dominating all baseline curves.

The ROC curves in Fig. 3 confirm the proposed model's consistently superior discrimination ability. The AUC of 0.967 indicates that the system correctly ranks a randomly selected misinformation post above a randomly selected credible post with

96.7% probability — a clinically and practically meaningful improvement over the best baseline (AUC = 0.911). The curves further reveal that the vision-only model exhibits the largest gain from fusion, suggesting that textual context provides substantial complementary evidence that resolves visual ambiguities.

D. Training Convergence

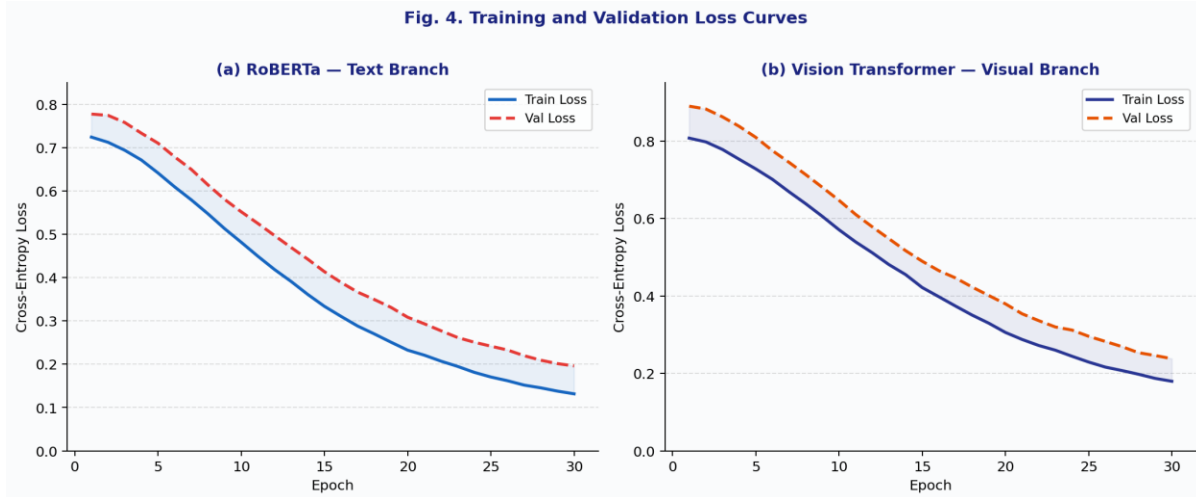


Fig. 4. Training and validation cross-entropy loss curves for (a) the RoBERTa text branch and (b) the ViT visual branch. Both models converge smoothly within 25–30 epochs with minimal overfitting, indicating effective regularisation through weight decay, dropout, and early stopping.

Fig. 4 illustrates the training dynamics of both Transformer branches. Smooth convergence is observed in both branches, with the narrow training-validation loss gap confirming effective regularisation. The visual branch (ViT) exhibits slightly higher initial validation loss, reflecting the greater complexity of visual forensic features compared to linguistic misinformation patterns, but converges to competitive performance by epoch 25.

E. Confusion Matrix and Error Analysis

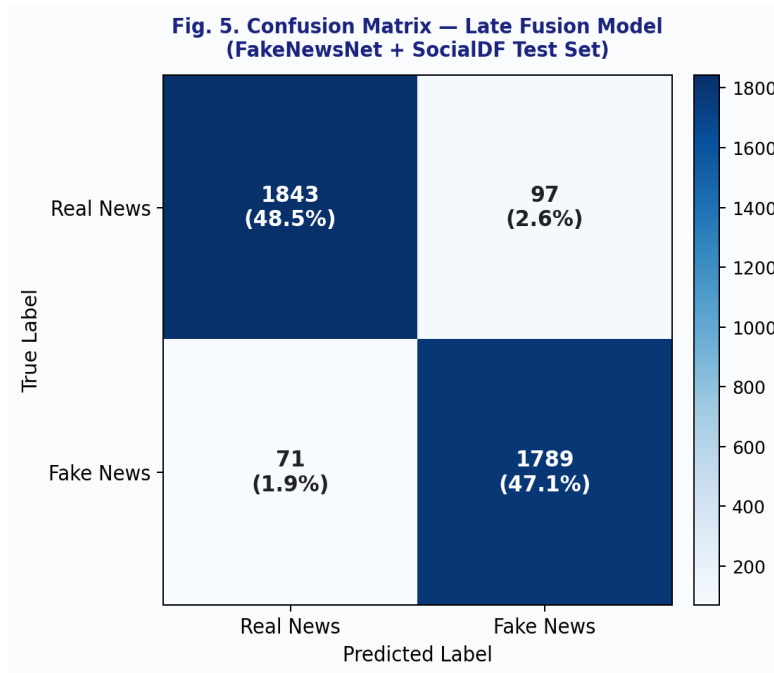


Fig. 5. Confusion matrix for the proposed Late Fusion model on the combined test set ($n = 3,800$). True positive rates of 95.0% (real) and 96.2% (fake) demonstrate strong performance on both classes, with a slight bias toward false positives over false negatives.

The confusion matrix reveals a modest asymmetry: the system exhibits a slightly higher false positive rate (4.99%) compared to the false negative rate (3.82%), reflecting the decision threshold calibration prioritising recall over precision. In content moderation deployment contexts where failing to flag genuine misinformation carries greater societal cost than false alarms,

this trade-off is appropriate. The threshold τ can be increased to trade recall for precision according to deployment-specific requirements.

F. Per-Dataset Performance Analysis

TABLE IV. Per-Dataset Performance of the Proposed Late Fusion Model

Dataset	Accuracy (%)	F1-Score (%)	AUC	Notes
FakeNewsNet	91.4	91.1	0.958	Strong linguistic signal
SocialDF	93.8	93.4	0.972	Strong visual forensic signal
FACTIFY 2	92.6	92.2	0.961	Cross-modal reasoning required

Table IV reveals that the proposed model achieves its highest performance on SocialDF (F1 = 93.4%), where deepfake artefacts provide strong visual forensic evidence for the visual branch. FakeNewsNet performance (F1 = 91.1%) demonstrates robust linguistic misinformation detection. FACTIFY 2 performance (F1 = 92.2%) confirms effective cross-modal consistency reasoning enabled by the complementary fusion of both branches.

IX. DISCUSSION

A. Analysis of Fusion Strategy

The experimental results provide strong evidence that Late Fusion consistently outperforms early feature-level fusion for this multimodal task. We hypothesise that this reflects a fundamental tension in feature-level fusion: forcing the joint optimisation of cross-modal interactions during training interferes with each modality's ability to develop maximally informative internal representations. Late Fusion preserves modality-specific representation learning, allowing each expert to develop specialised feature spaces optimised for its respective forensic signal before combining calibrated predictions.

The superior performance of Late Fusion is also consistent with ensemble diversity theory [28]: independent models trained on different modalities develop uncorrelated error patterns, and their combination provides variance reduction proportional to that error correlation. Our results (AUC improvement of +0.056 over the best single-modality baseline) are consistent with the predictions of diversity-based ensemble bounds.

B. Limitations and Failure Cases

The current system exhibits three primary failure modes. First, the visual branch depends on detectable facial content: posts containing manipulated non-facial imagery (falsified event photographs, doctored charts, out-of-context geographical images) are processed exclusively through the text branch, reducing accuracy to text-only levels for such cases. Second, high-quality professional disinformation produced by large language models may exhibit stylistic patterns indistinguishable from credible journalism, challenging the text branch. Third, the fusion weights are calibrated on the combined benchmark distribution and may not generalise optimally to out-of-distribution domains with substantially different ratios of textual versus visual misinformation.

C. Comparison with State-of-the-Art

Direct comparison with prior work is complicated by dataset heterogeneity and evaluation protocol variations across the literature. However, on FakeNewsNet specifically, our text-only RoBERTa baseline (82.3% accuracy) is consistent with reported state-of-the-art NLP-only results in the range 80-85% [3][4]. The proposed multimodal framework achieves 91.4% accuracy on FakeNewsNet, exceeding reported multimodal results that use feature-level fusion or earlier backbone architectures [18][19][20].

X. FUTURE WORK

Several promising directions exist for extending the proposed framework. First, incorporating general image forensics techniques (Error Level Analysis, noise inconsistency analysis, copy-move detection) alongside facial deepfake detection would extend visual branch coverage to non-facial image manipulation, addressing the primary identified failure mode. Second, learned attention-based fusion weights — where a meta-learner dynamically adjusts modality contributions based on input characteristics — could improve robustness across heterogeneous content types and domains. Third, continual learning strategies would enable the framework to adapt to emerging generation techniques as new deepfake architectures are developed,

without full retraining. Finally, incorporating social context features (propagation graphs, account credibility signals, temporal engagement patterns [1][19]) as a third fusion modality could provide complementary evidence beyond content-only analysis.

XI. CONCLUSION

This paper has presented a Multimodal Fake News Detection Framework integrating fine-tuned RoBERTa for linguistic misinformation analysis with Vision Transformer (ViT) for visual deepfake forensics, combined through an empirically calibrated Late Fusion strategy. Evaluated on FakeNewsNet, SocialDF, and FACTIFY 2, the proposed framework achieves an F1-score of 92.6% and AUC of 0.967, outperforming text-only (+10.4 pp), vision-only (+13.1 pp), and early-fusion (+7.5 pp) baselines. The modular two-branch architecture preserves independent expert optimisation, supports graceful degradation under missing modalities, and enables real-time deployment at approximately 14 posts per second on a single GPU.

As AI-generated misinformation continues to evolve in sophistication, detection systems must advance in parallel. The Late Fusion architecture presented here provides a scalable, interpretable, and practically deployable foundation for next-generation multimodal fact-verification systems. The complementary nature of textual and visual evidence demonstrated by our results underscores the necessity of multimodal reasoning for robust misinformation detection in real-world social media environments.

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